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Dr. Michael White

Dr. Michael White is a respected clarinetist, educator, music historian, and champion of early New Orleans jazz. He has performed with a lengthy list of equally accomplished musicians and continues to be involved in all aspects of the New Orleans musical heritage.

Michael was interviewed via Zoom on July 10, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm very happy to have Dr. Michael White from New Orleans here this morning. Thanks for joining me.

MW: Oh good morning. It's a pleasure.

MR: Before our tape was rolling we were talking about, you must have had a good reed. And it made me think of a comment that Evan Christopher made. I assume you know Evan Christopher?

MW: Yes, yes.

MR: He had this interesting comment about New Orleans, in that it was so humid that it affected how you played. And I wondered if he was making that up?

MW: Well you know a lot of things are debatable. I just came back from a tour in Morocco and I had the same horn, same reed, I didn't have any problems, it was the same. But it is very humid here and some people do believe that that affects the wood and the reeds and all of that. But I don't know, I haven't noticed that much of a difference to be honest.

MR: Yeah, there were some, one of the things I jotted down to talk about was jazz myths. And we can go there, but before I leave Evan, he had this theory about vibrato and that it was, if we listen to Sidney Bechet and others that it was wide partly because they were trying to deal with out of tune pianos.

MW: I don't know about that. I mean I know a lot of older musicians, I know a lot of – I've played with more than three dozen musicians born before 1910 and I never heard that. But you know there are a lot of things people – there's a lot unknown so a lot of times people make up things or they theorize. But you know I think the vibrato is just part of the idea of imitating the singing style that came from black churches and blues, and different singers had different types of vibrato and I think it was just a personal means of expression more than anything else. Because a lot of times when they played here they didn't have a piano you know.

MR: Yeah. Banjo or guitar?

MW: Right, right.

MR: Amongst the things I was watching you was something from 2017, a live recording of "Give it Up" and I had a couple of questions about it that I might as well bring up at this time. The first was almost like a practical thing. I noticed that the drummer had no cymbals other than a hi-hat. Was that on purpose?

MW: Yes. I wanted a certain sound. A lot of times I'm trying to get away from the generic common sound that you hear, and I had a certain sound in mind and I just kind of didn't want, you know like a sock cymbal in that. Because the tendency is to, you know, give the back beat on the sock cymbal and I didn't want that sound. I was looking for a different sound.

MR: I would say it makes it easier to hear the parts because I've always felt like cymbals especially Chinese cymbals that I'm not very fond of, they just seem to fill the whole spectrum. And I just noticed that listening to that I could really concentrate on the horns.

MW: Right. I have a problem with cymbals sometimes 'cause people don't realize, first of all cymbals, it's a musical tone. Those are notes and those notes sometimes clash with the chord or the key that you're in you know, as well as, as you said, fill up the space and kind of – the music to me has to breathe a certain kind of way and you don't want it all full. At least the music I play.

MR: Yeah. And speaking of breathing, it's like when I listen to this, physically I couldn't see it but I just felt like you were sucking in all the air in the room to project your sound so that it was very dynamic. And I don't have a question there, it's just an observation.

MW: Well you know I'm very much coming out of the traditional New Orleans, the Afro-Creole clarinet tradition. And I got to hear nine players that were born before 1912. And they all had these special unique sounds and tones, and you know I just learned a lot about projection. I mean Willie Humphrey, who had perhaps a generally thinner tone in the upper register, could project through anything. And he told me a lot about projection but also I started out playing in brass bands. I played four years in brass bands in community black social club parades, jazz funerals, and church parades. And in a brass band, you know you have to learn how to really project to cut through those lot of instruments. So I guess I focused on tone and projection. So that's always an important thing for me. You always have to put – you know not overblow, but you always have to put a steady amount of air in the horn and, you know, maintain that.

MR: How did you learn the repertoire that was required to play the gigs that you just mentioned?

MW: Oh, trial and error. It was like being thrown in the water. The first job I played for four years was with a brass band with Ernest "Doc" Paulin's Brass Band. And 90% of our work was for sessions I mentioned, community social club parades, jazz funerals, and church parades. And I had been listening to records like the Atlantic recordings "Jazz

Begins" with the Young Tuxedo Brass Band from the late 1950s. And luckily I started practicing with that and a number of the songs that Doc played were on that recording. Other songs you know I learned by trial and error. You find out that songs have chord structures, you're in a certain key, you have the chord structure and you kind of figure out what the chords are. And then you kind of play along with those chords. You listen to recordings, I listened to a lot of recordings to kind of figure out what the role of the clarinet was, in the brass bands, in the smaller groups. And in that it gave me sort of like a model that I would take off on. But also back then in the brass band, and the other groups, the older musicians would kind of mentor younger musicians and they would tell you people to listen to, they would make sometimes comments about your sound, different things, you're doing this right, this sounds really good, you know maybe you should check out a little George Lewis, check out Sidney Bechet, Johnny Dodds. And these are people that played with those guys so I got to get first-hand view of you know descriptions of how they sounded beyond the recording. And that kind of inspired me. And then you know with time I just listened to the kinds of tones that I liked. I liked the bigger, more expressive sounds, full tone. So I started listening to a lot of people: Sidney Bechet and Johnny Dodds, George Lewis, Edmond Hall, you know people like that. But I listened to everybody else of course, to Jimmy Noone, Barney Bigard, Omer Simeon, and those people kind of gave me a, collectively, an idea that oh I can have my own sound within that tradition. So I've been working on that over the years, sometimes, not successfully, but I finally kind of found my way. I experimented for many years with reeds, mouthpieces, ligatures, bells, horns, combinations – sometimes those combinations got me into trouble you know, intonation issues and all that. But you know I finally figured out that you know as some people say, it's you, it's not the horn, it's you. So I have, like this is a student horn and it's a plastic Conn but it sounds like me. I get a big full sound on it and all of that. But what I find is that there are instruments that let you be the best of you. And so you know I seek out those kinds of instruments. But I'm not as obsessed with all of those different things these days. I'm pretty settled on mouthpieces, reeds, and –

MR: You know Kenny Davern played a plastic clarinet too.

MW: Yes. And in fact he played a Conn 15 which this is.

MR: All right.

MW: He's the one that told me about them, and I bought them because I don't like to bring my good horns out in parades and funerals. But what I found is as good as it sounds out on the job, it just doesn't quite have the same bite as my good wooden clarinets.

MR: So if you were recording you'd take out your wooden clarinet?

MW: Yes. But what I find is I'm composing a lot these days. Every day. So I put a lot of wear and tear on wooden horns and I've cracked a few. And I certainly thank God, not my best ones, but I decided you know I'd better get something that can take it. So I bought a few of these. They're relatively inexpensive online, but the Conn 15. Yeah they're pretty good. You know you get a decent sound you know.

[plays]

MR: It's decent.

MW: It's decent. Yeah, it's okay. So I can use that to compose and get the different inflections I might hear in a song you know, that I want to get. And then it always sounds better on my good horn.

MR: Here's what – I can't believe this is 40 years old, the *Grove Dictionary of Jazz*, from 1980 and you're in it, and it says, "White's full-bodied tone and imaginative improvisations reminiscent of Johnny Dodds have established his reputation as one of the most exciting young New Orleans musicians.

MW: Oh. That was nice.

MR: It's nice.

MW: Pretty nice, yeah.

MR: I'm sure you have an updated – there's an updated version that they probably have a larger thing on you.

MW: Yeah I'll have to check it out. But yeah, you know it's a funny thing. I listened to a lot of different music before I got to the authentic New Orleans jazz style and sound. The first jazz I actually heard was bebop because there was a little of that on the radio and they used to have live broadcasts from this place called Lou and Charlie's and they featured you know some of the great modern jazz musicians in New Orleans like Ellis Marsalis and, you know, people like that. And I used to listen to those things. And then there was some jazz shows that had modern jazz, and I heard that. And then I also heard Dixieland like. But none of that really – I liked the modern jazz –

MR: Did you hear Buddy DeFranco at the time?

MW: No. It was much later when I heard Buddy DeFranco. I didn't even know clarinets played, you know, bebop style 'til later. And then I heard that music, I liked it as a listener, but it didn't speak to my – so when I heard the real New Orleans jazz it seemed to define what my life was about, what it felt like to be in and from New Orleans. It felt like that music was the way we think, the way we talk, the way older people thought. It was an expression of life. And so it immediately grabbed me, like this is what it means to be from New Orleans. This is our language so to speak. And it just – it wasn't a choice, it was something that just grabbed me. And so I started listening to that. And I heard Dixieland clarinet players a lot, because that was more promoted and better known and I

heard that, whether it be from people who played on Bourbon Street or on Lawrence Welk or something. But when I heard the real New Orleans jazz clarinet original style, it just spoke to me. So I started to listen to a lot of that kind of stuff, wherever I could find it. But it was hard to find back in the day, no YouTube and recordings were rare. So I sought out recordings. But it was a long process. And I started going to the New Orleans Jazz and Heritage Festival and I got to hear some older players there. So it was a combination of hearing recordings and older players playing live. I heard Willie Humphrey, Louis Catrell, Raymond Burke, Joseph Thomas, and then I heard Barney Bigard.

MR: Did you hear George Lewis live?

MW: I didn't hear George Lewis live. Ironically I was 13 years old when he died. I wasn't playing music then but that very same year that – he died on the last day of the year in 1968 but that very next year I started playing the clarinet. So I remember seeing his funeral on television and asking my mother, "Who is this George Lewis?" You know. So no I never got to hear him live. I got to play with a lot of people that played with him and they told me things about him. But it wasn't really until I accidentally stumbled on and bought a record of his, and when I heard that it completely changed my life.

MR: I don't know if this is a myth in my head, but when I was watching, just this morning I was watching a video of him and he would do a certain amount of, I call it "finger whacking." And I know Kenny Davern would do this too, like he'd lift certain fingers up and really almost percussively play the instrument that way. And I was thinking well a classical clarinet teacher would not appreciate that. If they had a ruler they might slap your wrist. But I'm wondering if that physicalness of the finger movement is part of how the sound comes out that you want?

MW: I believe that it is. I believe every physical – slight movements of the lip, the cheeks, all of those things affect the tone and the sound. I notice with Kenny, and I noticed with George Lewis in videos and stuff, he would – sometimes they would puff their cheeks out a little bit. Unfortunately I didn't learn how to do that and I don't know how to do that. But I also tried different things. Because what you realize is you want the instrument to be like your voice and an expression of how you feel so you don't have to do everything somebody else did. You can have, you know, people that you admire and you like their playing, you learn a little bit from this one here, that one there. But ultimately, just like you have your own handwriting, your own voice, your own facial features, your music and your sound to me should come from that. Come from you inside. So if you want to make some kind of bent tone effects and different things, you kind of have to experiment and learn how to do what you want to do. And you know there's things that other people do that I don't necessarily want to do, so there you go.

MR: Were you surprised along the way in your path through jazz history – I was, one time was reading a book and it mentioned one of those earlier New Orleans musicians and that they were a barber. And I think I was naïve enough to think that all those fellows, all they did was just play music. And I don't even know if that's possible then – it's hard now but was it possible then?

MW: Well you mean back in the early days of jazz?

MR: Yeah.

MW: Yeah I mean you know music for a lot of people was not a lucrative profession so I mean that's part of the reason why you had such a big migration of musicians out of New Orleans in the teens and the twenties. But I think that most of the musicians had other professions. So the thing I think you're referring to is that it was always said that Buddy Bolden was a barber. And thank God Don Marquis' book proved that wrong. You know bits in jazz are like grass, they're everywhere. But Buddy Bolden became – he was a musician more than anything else so I think he was one of the few early on but he was struggling, but he used to hang out in a barber shop. And the barber shop was on the corner from his house and you may or may not have read, I don't know if this is a set-up, but you may not have read that the barber shop where he hung out was owned and run by my relatives, Nelson Joseph and his brother John Joseph. John Joseph was Papa John Joseph, and he was one of the early jazz musicians. Because they were all musicians. Nelson played guitar, Papa John Joseph played a lot of different instruments. He was mainly a bass player but he also played clarinet and guitar and a little saxophone. He was one of the first saxophone players in jazz and played in brass bands. And they had a brother Willie who was a clarinetist who recorded in 1927. But Papa John ran the barber shop along with his brother, and then he had his own barber shop. Musicians used to hang out in the shop, congregate, book jobs from there, and there was a sign that said "musicians headquarters." And so people would come or call when they were home, to book musicians for jobs: parties, picnics, funerals, parades, things like that. I talked to some of the younger musicians at the time who hung out in the shop, and they would get lessons from older musicians about playing and just listen to all the talk that musicians had. So yeah, I mean I knew some of the older musicians had professions like mattress makers, bricklayers, sheet metal workers, some of them were insurance men, you know George Lewis for a while had to work as a stevedore on the levee as a longshoreman where he got injured. Some musicians also taught music on the side you know, things like that. So many of them had other professions. Because, you know, music just didn't pay enough to pay the bills. Competition was high, there were a lot of musicians around all the time so it was hard to really make a living playing music exclusively.

MR: I have a question about jazz and art and entertainment. Jazz is now in all the universities, and Jazz at Lincoln Center, it's all wonderful. But I was just reading – I wrote a review on this, there's a new book out and this fellow spoke about Gunther Schuller and how he approached early jazz more as an art form and this particular author does not apologize at all for the – it was entertainment. So I'm trying to form a question, Michael. Do you think that the musicians back then thought of what they were doing as art?

MW: Oh definitely no. I think to them, I don't think they necessarily thought of it as art as such, but it was an art you know. It was, because it involved a high degree and a high level of creativity. The thing that struck me about these musicians that I played with is how different they all sounded live. If they played an arpeggio, even if they played the same thing, if they played [plays clarinet] – if they all played that it would all sound different. And it was different tonal qualities, there were different inflections, just like different people talking. And that's what it was like. So I think without them necessarily considering it an art, but it was also entertainment. So it was what I would think of as a folk art. It was a functional art that was entertainment but it was other things. I think it was also an underground/undercover symbol for freedom and democracy because by the very act of playing the music it gave you a voice, it gave your intelligence, your personality a chance to be open out in the world in society, for people to see, to admire. So I think it was what you would call a folk art. So it was a combination of art, but art used for social purposes, functions, parades, dances, you know, sporting events, advertising wagons. And there's nothing wrong with having that combination. By the way what is the – who is the author of that book?

MR: It's called *Early Jazz, A Concise Introduction from its Beginning Through 1929* by Fumi Tomita, who is at University of Massachusetts Amherst.

MW: Oh, okay.

MR: Yeah. It's good. And he mentions some things about the novelty, the way people played novelty songs and all that, and he doesn't apologize for anything. It was like this is what it was and everybody was looking for their own voice and trying to please an audience. And I'm wondering if you think that current jazz education gives early jazz its due?

MW: Generally no. When I came up I started playing in the 1970s, one of the surprising things that I discovered was how much music education fluffs off early jazz. And this goes not only down to the literature but actual music teachers and programs. And they all have it put under the label of Dixieland, which implies something corny, invalid, not musical, and of course a lot of the music teachers were modern jazz players or failed modern jazz players, and they, you know they promoted what they liked. And, you know I remember hearing music teachers of jazz bands and stuff in school say, "Jazz began with Charlie Parker," of course, a common saying. Before that they think jazz was just some

embryonic form of noise that wasn't really valid. I've heard music teachers put down Louis Armstrong for example, saying he couldn't really play and this kind of stuff, and make jokes about him, make jokes about early jazz and early jazz musicians. So I had to kind of suffer through that prejudice against early jazz music and come to my own understanding of what the music was and what it meant. And fortunately I discovered and was able to interact with these older musicians who, you know, I was one of them because I was from here, my family, they all knew the musicians in my family, they had all played with Papa John and Willie Joseph and Earl Pouchet, who was in the family. So I was able to get a different view of what New Orleans jazz was like and what it was about. But there were a lot of problems. I mean in the '60s there was a problem, and in the '70s there was still this residue of the Civil Rights movement and people were thinking that anything old was a remnant of a past that needed to be forgotten or eliminated. And of course Louis Armstrong's image and his widely perceived image at the time didn't help. I mean people said he was an Uncle Tom, a lot of people boycotted him, they made fun of the music he played, and of course it didn't sound like – it was popular but it didn't sound like the music he played in the '20s and the '30s. You know it was a lot more commercial and so it took me quite a bit to really unearth and find out what traditional New Orleans jazz really was. But luckily, you know, there was the older musicians, there were still the functions. I mean what I really discovered with jazz was it was when I started playing in the brass bands and I could see it had nothing to do with Bourbon Street, tourists, commercialism or money for that matter. We weren't making it. It was a way of bonding and sharing with the community. And in that I could see how the music was an expression of the lives of the people: the way they walked, the way they danced, the way they laughed, older people hanging in the doorframe. The music was them. It was those expressions. It was the way people thought and talked and the way they cooked food. You know it was New Orleans in sound. Now to finish your question –

MR: Yeah, go ahead.

MW: Oh to finish the question, most music teachers are only taught classical music and modern jazz. And so they fluff over early jazz as something invalid. Now if I only had to hear what is all over the country as the Dixieland that I've heard, I wouldn't have liked it and wouldn't have gotten into it either. But you know, so they put that label on early jazz music and they think that's what it is and that's how it sounds and all of that. And so no, I mean a lot of music schools – it's partly because a lot of music teachers, what I find is they don't know about it, they don't want to know about it, they don't understand it, so they just kind of fluff it off as invalid. You know, learn all these bebop scales and imitate Charlie Parker and John Coltrane and that's real jazz you know.

MR: I think you started to answer my question because I think it's probably harder to teach this music. Because try to think of the last time you saw a New Orleans style jazz group play with music stands in front of them. And I don't think the music lends itself to being codified, to have all those scales and it's such a personal thing, and all those connections, those community connections you just mentioned that are part and the reason for the music. How do you teach that? And if someone can't teach it they decide well maybe it's not worth teaching.

MW: Well yeah, and also I mean just the fact that a lot of later generation people, you know, you like the music of your generation or whatever, and a lot of people just didn't respect it 'cause it was old, or they didn't respect it because they didn't think it was hip. You know they didn't use as many scales and altered things and it wasn't, in general, as fast and technical. You know it presented a different kind of challenge. It wasn't something that you could sit down and say analyze and say this is this scale and you practice this for so many hours, months – weeks, months – and you can come out and play it on the job and people think you're raising hell. It's – how do you play from the soul? How do you develop a real, genuine, original self-expression, and how do you do that in collective improvisation? How do you create while other people are creating collectively to create a tapestry that's greater than any one individual. Yeah, that's hard to teach. However, I mean and in this country it has a lot of different implications, some of which are racial implications and all this, but there are people, no matter what anybody says, there are people all over the world of all ages and all nationalities that play authentic New Orleans style jazz. They're not necessarily going to schools to learn it, they learn it from listening to records and getting with people in places like in Japan, the second largest university there, Waseda University, there's a New Orleans jazz club that started in the 1960s as a result of George Lewis's first three month tour there, and they have several bands of musicians. Some of the musicians are deceased now, a number of them are older than me, and they still have kids, you know 18, 19 years old learning this music, come over to New Orleans, they sound so much like the early musicians 'til it's frightening. But there are people all over Europe, all over Scandinavia, you know Norway, Sweden, Finland, France, England, Germany, Australia playing this music, Canada. And you know some of the younger people that I see, it's refreshing to hear them because some of them, you know people always say, "Oh well they're just copying what somebody else played." Some people were, but there are a lot of people now playing this music creatively. Because they understand that there are a set of musical principles that can be used to endless creation, or at least for developing your own original style and you know you can have a mentor or an idol that you sound something like, but you know when I went to Morocco the trombone player was a young lady from Japan who now lives in New

Orleans and she sounds more like the authentic trombone style than most people in New Orleans today you know. There's a guy, a young guy from Canada, Toronto, who moved to New Orleans and he plays bass and he sounds like the old bass players. He sounds like Chester Zardis and Bill Johnson and Al Morgan you know and all these people. But he's very creative you know. And so that's – the way I feel about the music, I'm finding that some of these younger people all over the world feel the same way that you can play this music and be yourself. And they are not learning in school, and they are not having people, you know, some of them never get to New Orleans, some of them come to New Orleans, some of them move to New Orleans. So, but there have been people playing this music all along. The music of the 1920s had some influence and in some places you see people trying to play like King Oliver. Of course in France there were a lot of people trying to replicate Sidney Bechet's music. But what probably had the biggest impact was the New Orleans revival, Bunk Johnson and George Lewis. And so the majority of bands I hear from other places are influenced by that. You know George Lewis's band, Kid Thomas Valentine, people like that. And again, it varies. You have some people that are, you know, copying and imitating, and other people that are creative in the style.

MR: If you had, in your travels if you met a young musician who was really doing well in the music you're describing, and they want to come to New Orleans and enter the music scene, would you have some specific advice? Well you better – fill in the blank.

MW: Better not come.

MR: That was a set-up I think.

MW: You know there have been, since Hurricane Katrina there has been a generation of musicians, dozens of musicians that have migrated to New Orleans, and they live here and they play. And to me it's a double edged sword. Some of them are playing very well early style jazz music of all kinds and are very serious about it and are playing on a very high level and I love it. I think it's great. You know? It's great to hear that music live. It's great to have people that take it seriously and respect it you know. But on the other hand from a business perspective and from a New Orleans perspective a lot of musicians are happy to be in New Orleans, happy to play, and some people play let's just say for low fees. And it makes it harder for professional musicians in New Orleans. A lot of people come here and claim to be New Orleans musicians and they travel all over the world very cheaply and it makes it hard for some of the real New Orleans musicians to go out and you know, under the professional conditions that you should go out under. You know? So it's kind of like a double edged sword in a way. But it's very difficult, You know like we were talking about earlier, people go through music schools and different things and they learn how to play, but they don't really learn about this music so a lot of times the guys that play think oh it's just a set of chords and I can just play my little bebop style over it

and that works and that's it. And then they wonder why they don't get, you know, attention and a career like other people but it's that generic style, it doesn't have the same impact as the real New Orleans jazz. I mean it's a valid style. It's not about how old it is or how many scales or chords you play over this and that. I mean it's twelve notes, and I find that I use all the notes and everything but it's how you use them you know.

MR: Are there mistakes that you can make? Because the reason I ask that is of the middle generation of musicians I've asked about mistakes in improvisation most of them say there's no mistakes.

MW: You know its funny you should say that. I feel – I felt mistakes all the time, but if you're going to create you're going to make mistakes. But the good part, and what I think they refer to is if you can make something happen from those mistakes. You know? Which you can do. I mean really every note is just a half-step away from something that's good so you just make it part of the movement. But you know I started, this is something that people don't know, but I play traditional New Orleans jazz mainly but I also go all the way to the other end and play a little avant garde.

MR: Like Kidd Jordan down there, right?

MW: Yes. And he kind of found that out near the end. But for most of my life I didn't like it. People thought I couldn't get into that and this, that and the other. But I met a clarinet player, Perry Robinson, who was from New York and he was an underground legend of the loft movement of the '60s and he played and recorded with a number of people in the avant garde vein. He was an older guy, and he came down to New Orleans to play. And, long story short, I sat in with him and he kept asking me to sit in. There were not a lot of people in the audience so I said what the heck. And I said, but man I'm really a traditional New Orleans player and I don't know anything about this stuff you're doing. And he said that one thing that was also life changing – he said don't worry about it, there are no mistakes in this music. And I was like huh? No mistakes? And that gave me the confidence to go on. And I started playing that, and I ended up playing a festival with him, the Vision Festival in New York, playing avant garde. I did it in Israel. I met an old legendary clarinet player there named Harold Rubin, and I also played with Perry in New York a few other times, and you know part of what I compose is in that vein. And you know I hear, strangely, a relationship between early New Orleans jazz and avant garde. And I like it. The reason I really could relate to it I think, I started listening to Albert Ayler you know, "Ghosts and Spirits" and all that. But I started playing with an African balafon player who had a band, and you know I had to learn how to play – improvise and play solos on one chord. You know? And over different kinds of rhythms. And that leaned toward avant garde. So at the same time I was, like thousands of other people, severely affected by hurricane Katrina. I lost my home, everything, it cost years of trying

to get back to some state of normalcy, or living in the new existence. It was very painful. There were a lot of losses. I went through a plethora of emotions: bewilderment, anger, you know of being frightened, fear. Little joy here and there. And I needed to express those things. I wrote a bunch of songs at a artist's retreat here called Studio in the Woods, A Studio in the Woods. And I recorded them on a recording called "Blue Crescent." And the idea was it was kind of like my version of the state of New Orleans post-Katrina. Most of the songs ended up being uptempo or nostalgic, optimistic and hopeful. There's only one song that's really kind of sad, it's called "Katrina." I can't even play it it's that sad. But what I found is that even with all of those new songs that I wrote, there was still feelings that I wasn't able to express in traditional music. And I found with the avant garde I could scream, I could shout, I could curse, I could question in ways that I couldn't in conventional musical forms. And so I continued with that, and most people, even a lot of the musicians have no idea that I do that. It's like a secret. It has to be a secret because most people hate it. But you know I learned a lot from Perry Robinson. We played this concert and, you know, we walked out, I'd just met the musicians five minutes before. We walked out on the stage. He says, he wrote out one line and he said, "We're going to play this in harmony, you play this part I play that and then we'll take off from there." And I'm thinking we're going to do a concert and this is all we have is one line? You know. And then we walked out on the stage and he said, "Look, let's just do the first song just the two clarinets together." And I'm like – he said, "I'll play something and then you answer and then we'll meet in the middle." And I was like, what could I say? So he started playing and I started playing, and something happened. It was something spiritual that happened and we connected and it was really beautiful in a different kind of way from what I'm used to. And I went with it. So ever since, I mean every now and then in my daily compositions something'll come out that's avant garde sounding and I'll write out a line or two and use those as points of departure. But the problem is of course it's hard to find community here in that. It's not going to be a lucrative endeavor. Jazz clubs and stuff wouldn't want that. You know I would have to have a special concert to be able to play that music. So I'd need to find people that are interested. It's very unfortunate that I wasn't able to really hook up with Kidd Jordan before he passed. You know near the end I sat in with him a couple of times, like in Chicago at the Chicago Jazz Fest. He played at this club, you know, and I played with a bunch of other people, and it was great. And there were a couple of times I was able to do that. But I learned a lot from that. I mean you know Kidd's concept of listening to sounds around you certainly has become a part of my artistic composition style. You know people would laugh and say, "Oh Kidd would make a song off the sound of the air conditioner." You know and everybody thought that was crazy and funny and all of that. But I realized, you know, like I listen

especially to things that have rhythm. I realized in the old days the train was a very important part of, you know early blues and jazz, the rhythm of the train and the symbolism of the train. It represented progress, it represented movement, it represented freedom, it represented going north and all of those things. But at the same time it gave great rhythms that you could, you know, take off on on songs. So now I try to hear rhythm through things. And It's simple things now that catch my attention. It might be an old rickety fan as it turns around and maybe a certain rhythm in that. I remember going to the cleaners, the dry cleaners a couple of months ago and hearing that and I recorded it. And I came home and wrote a song based on that rhythm. But nowadays things like the windshield wiper gives a lot of good rhythm. It might be a clothes dryer, a washing machine, something like that. So you, you know, and I use that not only in the avant garde kind of stuff but in traditional music too.

MR: Say how do you – if you compose a melody with that particular rhythm as an inspiration do you then move on to, "Well I need some chord structure here?" Or do you try not to think that way?

MW: I try not to think about chords initially. I try to think about sound and phrases. Melodic phrases. And then after I go for a while then I'm let's see now, how many bars is this, what are the chords. And I might start to put chords on top of it or might not initially. I might wait to the end and try to figure out what they are. But I don't want to be too constricted by structure and traditional structure. I want to kind of hear my own thing sometimes. Sometimes I use conventional structures very easily, like the blues. So if I hear a windshield wiper that, you know I was at the red light the other day [claps rhythm]. And sometimes the movement is the backbeat. So you hear that you know, and that might imply something like [plays clarinet]. You know, something like that. And then I'll take off on the melody from there. But the rhythm is what inspires those melodies. So I think rhythm is extremely important in that sense. You know, but in terms of, I wanted to finish that thing out about the music schools, two things. One is in order to teach that music, the first thing you have to do is respect it. You have to understand that this is a valid art form, it's as valid as bebop or post-bebop or any other form of jazz. And it has certain musical principles. The problem is that people don't know the history and they think it's just this comic, fast, straw hat, Dixieland stuff and that's kind of like wrong. You know that exists and that's kind of like some kind of offshoot and all of that, but that's not what this music is. It's not what it's about. But you see it commercialized that way many times, and people, you know, "New Orleans jazz, oh this" you know and they expect you to be you know goofy acting and playing all kind of corny stuff and all that. I hate that stuff I really do. That's not what I play. That's not the tradition I come from. So the other thing is in terms of music schools, Juilliard in recent years has been

pioneering in the fact that they've included early New Orleans jazz as part of their repertoire, and for several years before Covid I was a guest coach and I would go in and coach several bands that had the charge of playing the music of let's say King Oliver or Jelly Roll Morton, and what they would do is they would have to transcribe the song. Everybody had to transcribe all the parts and then they would put it together and then they would all, you know, play the songs, and I would go in and talk about the tempo, the volume, the feeling, what was going on with the rhythm, things like that. And I really loved it, and it was great to hear them seriously approaching the music without feeling that they had to put bebop in it. They didn't sound like bebop players. You know? So I'd go to a concert with them, you know, playing King Oliver, the next night they're playing Charles Lloyd or something and they sound like that, you know, so that was amazing to me. But what that does is, and then there are a lot of other players I think influenced by YouTube that don't think that you know the older modern jazz is the only way to go in playing jazz. So I like people who are experimenting in different styles. Guys that experiment in the more modern styles I like that but also experimenting in traditional styles. Because you know I write songs every day that are different. And they are influenced by a wide range of things. You mentioned "Give It Up" – the song I wrote "Give It Up" which has evolved now to include a big drum solo and a clarinet and drum duet. But that song, which some people say sounds like klezmer to them originally was influenced by a Jabbo Smith song. I heard that and I was thinking about the structure and that's what I was coming at. You know? But I wanted to write songs that have catchy, simple melodies that people could relate to after the band stops playing, that the next day they're humming that melody.

MR: Oh that's such a great statement. Something that puts a hook in your ear.

MW: Yes. So I've had people tell me that they hear that song long after we play it. I hear people say that they hum it walking down the street. And my sister, who does not like jazz, told me, "You know I keep humming that little song you wrote and it's a simple thing and that's the hardest thing to do is something really simple. It's just three notes. It's like [plays clarinet]. You know? And in harmony and with the rhythm and everything it's very danceable. But I find that the – and I started listening to all kinds of jazz and I find that simple melodic statements are so hard to do but those are the most effective. That have meaning. You know? So I find that you tend to want to play arpeggios and scales over things a lot of times but to try to find something that has a little meaning, that's unique and that says something is hard. You know? So I look for that.

MR: Yeah. It's distinctive too because you've got the little lick landing on different beats, which I think really makes a huge difference.

MW: Right, right. You play with the rhythm. You know? But it's in the way that people feel and can relate to. And you know I think of New Orleans jazz even if I'm playing at Carnegie Hall. I think of New Orleans jazz as dance music. And I think it should always feel that way whether people are dancing or not. I mean that's what its original main function was when I came up playing in the brass bands. In New Orleans people don't look at a parade, they become part of the parade. And they follow and they do these dances, a second line dance is very creative, and it is as creative as the music. And it inspires the music and the music inspires the dancing. So I always think of New Orleans jazz music as dance music, and if it's not where people can dance I want them to feel like they want to dance. You know? And that's one of the greatest compliments we get when people say, "This music made me want to dance, I mean we couldn't dance but I felt like dancing, my feet were moving." You know. And all of that. It makes people feel the rhythm in the statements that you're playing.

MR: Yeah. I just got this phrase in my head from all these, that you've been saying, that for me the music is usually happy, but following up on what you said about Dixieland it's happy but it's not funny. It's not meant to be comical.

MW: Yes.

MR: And, but it's joyous.

MW: Yes. There is a difference between joy and, you know being absurd and stupid. Somebody in recent years made a statement that they thought was cute, they said, "In New Orleans we put" what did they say, "we put the fun in funeral." And they highlight the word "funeral" with like maybe a red F-U-N. And I was thinking to myself what idiot would say something like that. Because funerals are not fun. When people are joyously dancing and everything at the end of the funeral, that's not fun. That's to symbolize the joy you feel at a person's release from earthly burdens and movement transition to a higher state of existence. It's not fun. You know? But somebody with a commercial minded thing, you know, they think oh that's fun. It's not fun. You know so a lot of times also music was very functional. And so I learned from a more functional way. I mean playing concerts for stationary audiences was something that came along much later. I played you know parades, I played dances for older people you know where they dance to this music. I played parties, weddings, things like that. And then, you know, more public concerts came along later. But I used to play in the French Market a lot in the French Quarter along the river, and in the French Market people would pass and a lot of people would dance. They would be local people that would come out and dance. So you know I got used to that component of the music. And I always wanted to feel like that. Even if it's slow, sad music there's a certain movement that goes along with it.

MR: I was going to ask you to define a slow drag for me.

MW: A slow drag? To me a slow drag is a form of – a danceable song that is in a slow tempo and is sensuous, makes you want to dance close together you know. And dance in rhythm but slow. You know? Something like [plays clarinet]. You know.

MR: And you are your own drummer. Right?

MW: Well yeah. Because I'm tapping my feet, I don't know if you could hear that. But yeah you have to think about rhythm all the time and play rhythmically also. I've learned – it's one of the things you learn all along. You have to be able to play without a drummer. And in fact now I would say 50% of the jobs I do are without a drummer. I have a quartet that plays functions like weddings and parties, it's banjo, bass, clarinet, and trumpet.

MR: You have a stand-up?

MW: Yeah. Upright bass. Definitely. And I had two jobs like that this past weekend. And I enjoy it. You know it's – one modern jazz musician heard us and he said, "Man when I came in here and I saw you all without a drummer I thought it wouldn't be good, I thought it would be terrible" he said. "But you all got to the essence of this music, that ensemble playing was so great." "You didn't need a drummer" he said, "in fact a drummer would have taken away from it." He said, "This is like a chamber music version of New Orleans jazz." I said yeah. So it's a different kind of playing, it's more challenging in a way, but it's easier to play you know different registers of the horn without a drummer. And it's easier to play a different volume and make the music, you know, put more inflections and shifts and that's one of the things I've noticed a lot of the early musicians did. You know when you play a phrase not every note is at the same volume. Just like when you're talking. And that's the whole idea. Orally – probably hard to teach. It's harder to teach than to teach a scale that goes over a certain chord. So yeah it would be challenging.

MR: And don't forget about the rests.

MW: Yes. Space is very important as well. Because the music has to breathe. Even if the rhythm plays and there's nothing quite going on right there, if it's breathing in part of the rhythm it can be great. One of the interesting players I played with was Kid Thomas Valentine, who was a trumpet player. He was born in 1896, before Louis Armstrong. And he had his own kind of style, big beautiful, expressive tone. But he was what I would call a minimalist. He reminded me of middle-period Miles Davis in that sense in that he would leave a lot of spaces. He played a basic melody his own way, his own phrasing, his own tone. But he would leave spaces and it was good to do a response to or play rhythms or obbligato with. But also then it would still have spaces. And somehow that made the music flow a certain kind of way. It was great you know, because you just hear the rhythm of the banjo and the bass and the drum in between all that, it was beautiful.

MR: This has really been a fascinating conversation, we could do a part two and part three. What's next up for you? Are you going to go compose after we're done here?

MW: Yes. I feel like it. But what's really next up for me is, you know, I was very blessed to have seen the musicians I saw and played with and heard, and really to have the New Orleans heritage you know. Travel all over the world playing this music and meet all kinds of people, musicians. Earlier this year I wrote a – I was commissioned to write a song for the Lincoln Center Jazz Orchestra and I wrote the song and I played along with them. I wrote this song called "New Orleans Humbug." And it's based on later New Orleans jazz bands and early swing bands, that little thing that came along in the late 1920s and early '30s. So I'm doing more compositions. I want to record. Now I have hundreds of songs, because I write every day. It's been a real blessing. And I want to record some of those songs, different styles, different configurations. But the most important thing I think is I recently completed a memoir and I talk a lot about real New Orleans, what it's like growing up in New Orleans, musical life in New Orleans, the good part and the difficulties. Being a young person trying to get into traditional music when people my age and in earlier generations thought I was nuts or just square or something. You know discovering my own way of overcoming you know adversity and things that happened in my early life through the music, dealing with and surviving Hurricane Katrina. All of those kinds of things. And I thought it was important at this time to get that out. So I finished that, it is now at the publishers being edited by them. I work with their editor in a couple of months, and hopefully without too too much time it'll be out. So I'm looking forward to that and I'm hoping to have a companion recording of some of these original songs to go with it.

MR: Wonderful. Well if I ever get back down to New Orleans I hope I can buy you a drink of your choice at a club of your choice.

MW: Probably water and iced tea but that's fine. It would be a pleasure to meet you, and like you said you know if you want to do another part two or three or whatever, I have a lot of stories. I can talk about the older musicians you know that told me what it was like playing with Bunk Johnson, Louis Armstrong, Sidney Bechet. Some of those musicians grew up on the bandstand on the side of King Oliver in Chicago you know. Like at Lincoln Gardens and those places. And what was the other name for it, I can't think of it right now. But anyway I played with musicians that recorded in the '20s and had all kinds of experiences that they shared, and that's become part of my life and my music, so –

MR: Were you ever, let's say doing one of the marches and you were young and have one of the older musicians sort of give you that look? Like get off my note, kid?

MW: Yes. Well the band leader one time kind of told me early on, he said, "You're too light, you're too light." Too light? I was like, "What do you mean too light?" But what he

meant was my sound was too light in this big brass band, you couldn't hear me, the sound was thin. I talked to different musicians about sound and projection and I listened to clarinet players on record in brass band and stuff, and I realized I needed to project more. I needed a bigger sound. So I started working on that with more open mouthpieces, harder reeds and things like that. And that helped me. And then I started to find out where the secret open spaces were in the music and make sure I would fill in through there. And eventually I developed a sound and style that, you know, worked very well in the brass bands. And people would say, "I could hear you from blocks away" you know. But yeah, I mean they would tell you things like that, you know a way of indirectly telling you you need to work on something. You know, "You need to work on your sound." You know.

MR: Constructive criticism.

MW: Yes, yes. It was always constructive. It wasn't meant to destroy you because they wanted to see people come along playing the music. You know a lot of the older musicians before they died would always say, "It's up to you or to your generation to keep this music going." So they were always very encouraging.

MR: Yeah. Well thank you for keeping this music going.

MW: I'm trying.

MR: All right. I'll pause here and we'll say our good-byes.

MW: Okay, great. Thank you very much.